The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

Donald Trump warned **Iran** that “bad things will happen” if it fails to reach a deal over its nuclear programme within the next 15 days. The president’s ultimatum came after officials confirmed that America has deployed enough military resources in the region to attack Iran by this weekend. The prospect of war pushed the price of Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, to its highest level in six months.

Andrew Mountbatten-Windsor, formerly Prince Andrew, was released from police custody after being arrested on suspicion of misconduct in public office. The investigation, which remains open, follows the release of a vast email archive of Jeffrey Epstein, a dead sex offender whom Mr Mountbatten-Windsor was close to. In a statement King Charles III, his brother, said “the law must take its course.” Mr Mountbatten-Windsor has denied wrongdoing.

Nvidia will reportedly reduce its planned investment in **OpenAI** from $100bn to $30bn. According to the *Financial Times*, the two companies could finalise the deal this weekend. Investors’ worries about the AI sector have dragged down tech firms’ share prices. OpenAI plans to reinvest much of the new capital in Nvidia’s chips.

America and **Indonesia** signed a **trade deal,** cutting the Trump administration's tariffs on Indonesian goods to 19% from 32%. Indonesia will drop duties on almost all imports from America. It will also spend an additional $33bn on American products, including oil and aircraft. The agreement was signed at the inaugural meeting of the Board of Peace, an American-led body that plans to rebuild Gaza.

America's trade deficit narrowed slightly to $901.5bn in 2025, just 0.2% lower than in 2024, despite Mr Trump's sweeping tariffs. Trade in goods with China fell sharply, but imports from Vietnam, Mexico and India rose. In December the deficit widened by 33% month on month to $70.3bn, fuelled by a surge in imports.

Venezuela passed a law granting amnesty to some political prisoners. It will free hundreds of people locked up during various protests over the past 25 years. Venezuela has carried out a series of reforms since America ousted Nicolás Maduro, the country's president, in January. Critics say that the amnesty law does not go far enough. It excludes prisoners accused of working with foreign countries, for example.

Mr Trump ordered government agencies to release files related to **aliens** and **unidentified flying objects** because of the "tremendous interest" they have generated. The announcement came shortly after he criticised Barack Obama for revealing "classified information" on a podcast in which the former president claimed that aliens may be real. Mr Trump himself said he did not know whether they exist.

Figure of the day: 15%, the share of annual GDP spent on the American welfare state. Read the full story.

Photograph: Getty Images

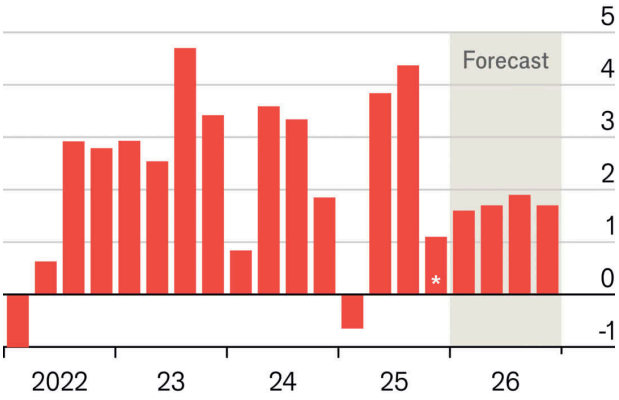
America’s economy is booming

The American economy has been on a tear. After a rocky patch last year, when Donald Trump’s tariffs and immigration shutdown weighed on growth, it looks strong again. In the third quarter of 2025, GDP grew by 4.3% on an annualised basis—well above the impressive 2.5-3% clocked up between 2022 and 2024. Fourth-quarter figures, due on Friday, are expected to be only slightly lower, at 2.3%, despite the government shutdown in October and November.

The Trump administration is forecasting even faster growth this year. The One Big Beautiful Bill Act, a tax-cutting law enacted in July, will soon hand Americans $191bn in refunds. Mr Trump is still crusading for interest-rate cuts—which might rev up the economy further. The White House’s preferred model, from the Federal Reserve Bank of Atlanta, at one point predicted 5.4% annualised growth for the fourth quarter. That has since been trimmed to 3%—though distortions by tariffs and the shutdown are probably inflating the figure.

Cash flow

United States, GDP, % change on previous quarter, annualised



Sources: Federal Reserve Bank of Philadelphia; Haver Analytics

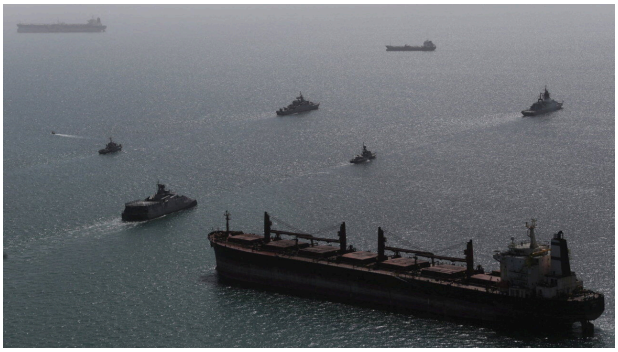
*Estimate

Photograph: Getty Images

Supreme Court decisions incoming

America's Supreme Court may rule on at least one of 27 outstanding cases on Friday. Two particularly notable cases might be ready. The most anticipated is *Learning Resources v Trump*, a challenge to some of President Donald Trump's tariffs from a wine importer and a toy company. When the court heard the case in November, most justices seemed sceptical of Mr Trump's authority to impose tariffs without clearer congressional approval. If the tariffs are struck down, it could roil global markets—though Mr Trump would have other, more limited avenues to reinstate the levies.

The second closely watched case is *Louisiana v Callais*, which concerns the Voting Rights Act, passed in 1965 to end racial discrimination in elections. The Supreme Court is expected to make it much harder for plaintiffs to challenge electoral maps on those grounds. That would give Republican-led states more freedom to draw their own voting districts, which could dilute the voting power of African-Americans and boost the GOP's chances in future elections.



Photograph: Iranian Army/WANA/Reuters

America readies itself to attack Iran

The largest warship in the world is steaming towards Iran. The *USS Gerald R. Ford* will soon join another aircraft-carrier already stationed in the Arabian Sea, as America amasses military might in the Middle East. Dozens of fighter jets and warplanes arrived this week after a second round of nuclear talks between America and Iran proved inconclusive.

After the meeting in Geneva on Tuesday, Iran's foreign minister said there had been "general agreement on some guiding principles". American officials were even less ebullient, and no date was set for a third meeting. President Donald Trump has given the Iranians "15 days" to come back with a more detailed proposal on curtailing their nuclear programme, and has warned that "bad things" will happen if they don't. The Pentagon says America will be capable of launching a strike by the weekend. An attack is looking likelier by the day.

Photograph: A24

Coronets to private jets: an oldie remade

In “How to Make a Killing”, out in America on Friday and elsewhere soon, the outcast scion of a mega-rich Long Island clan schemes to inherit its fortune—by bumping off all his rival heirs. Starring Glen Powell, who is charming even as a serial killer, the delightfully mordant movie is an update of the Ealing comedy of 1949, “Kind Hearts and Coronets”, in which the tale unfolds in Edwardian England.

The new film adopts parts of the original plot, including some elaborate murder methods, and tweaks others. What is striking is how perfectly the story fits today’s tetchily unequal age. Once again, plutocrats set impossible standards of luxury. Meanwhile the “great wealth transfer”, whereby baby-boomers are passing on assets worth trillions of dollars, spreads both jackpots and resentments across the income spectrum. This is one of several recent dramas that depict the ensuing tensions, and is among the most entertaining.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Friday: When Alexander Graham Bell made the first telephone call, who did he call?

Thursday: Which Canadian business, originally founded in 1670 and noted for its department stores, was finally liquidated in 2025?

The secret of being a bore is to tell everything.

Voltaire